GHOST STORY



Since the loss in the Bihar election, Lalu Prasad Yadav's estranged elder son **Tej Pratap** seems to have found solace in a YouTube channel. TY Vlog promises an 'authentic look into the everyday lifestyle of Tej Pratap'. It even includes ghostly pursuits. In a late night video from December 11, he senses "negative energy", with shaking trees, eerie sounds, and even a "white-clad figure" followed by a hurried exit after his cameraman collapses. It all seems to be going down well in Bihar, for Tej has in just weeks collected 110,000 followers.

The Red Card



Soccer superstar Lionel Messi may not have had a ball in Kolkata, but he certainly sent the administration into fits. After the much-hyped non-event at Salt Lake stadium, sports minister **Aroop Biswas** of the TMC stepped down, setting off a domino effect, with a DCP getting suspended, show-cause notices to the Bengal DGP and Bidhannagar police commissioner, the stadium CEO being eased out, and an SIT set up to look into the unholy mess. Offsides, fouls and penalties did take place, it turns out, just not on the pitch.

HIGH AND DRY



BJP legislator **Abhimanyu Pawar**, a former PA to Maharashtra CM **Devendra Fadnavis**, received an unusual, public rap from his boss recently. While speaking in the House, Pawar said a big problem confronting Ladki Bahin, the flagship welfare scheme for women, was the menace of illicit liquor. Fadnavis bristled at the reference, warning Pawar against "invoking the scheme to frame every issue", and even issued a blunt reminder—persist and "you'll be sitting at home".



Kaushik Deka with Amitabh Srivastava, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar and Dhaval S. Kulkarni

HEALTH WATCH

By **Sonali Acharjee**

LEPROSY-FREE BY 2027
MAHARASHTRA FACES ITS FEARS

Maharashtra's decision to make leprosy a notifiable disease—requiring all healthcare providers to report every case within two weeks—marks a long overdue shift in how India confronts one of its persistent public health problems. The state, a known hotspot, now aims for a leprosy-free Maharashtra by 2027.



Despite India officially reaching elimination levels in 2005, leprosy never truly disappeared. "In 2005, India met the leprosy elimination criteria of under one case for every 10,000 people nationally. But around a fourth of the 800 districts in the country remain high-burden," says Dr Ashok Agarwal, CEO of NLR India, a non-profit that supports leprosy victims and works towards its elimination. He says nearly 100,000 new cases are reported each year, but that only reflects those detected in the public system—many more are diagnosed in private clinics or never come forward due to stigma.

The disease is preventable and easily treatable, becoming non-infectious after the first dose of multi-drug therapy. Yet an NLR India assessment found 79 per cent of families and community members hold negative attitudes, while almost half the patients report poor mental wellbeing. Overcrowding, poor nutrition and hygiene fuel transmission, whose symptoms—often just a pale, numb skin patch—may appear only after 2-5 years.

Experts say India can eliminate leprosy with a multi-year strategy centred on early detection, contact tracing and community awareness—crucial steps in a nation of 1.4 billion where silence, more than science, keeps the disease alive.